

# Leading in the American Branch

Instructor guide for Japanese and Chinese managers navigating directness, pushback, and conflict in US teams

**Audience: instructors, coaches, HR learning partners, and senior facilitators**

Focus: cultural leadership, pragmatic communication, meeting behavior, conflict repair, and confident pushback in US branch environments.

Designed for advanced Japanese and Chinese managers who already have functional English and need a clearer map of American workplace expectations.

Teaching stance: culture is a pattern, not a prison. The materials describe common workplace expectations and perception gaps, then ask learners to observe the actual company, team, role, and person in front of them.

## Purpose and Teaching Position

This auxiliary EFSP curriculum is for advanced adult managers who do not primarily need grammar correction. They need cultural maps, leadership practice, and pragmatic language for situations where American workplace behavior feels confrontational, assertive, or personally aggressive.

The course does not teach learners to imitate a stereotype of American aggressiveness. It teaches them to recognize the local meaning of direct challenge, respond with calm authority, and decide when the behavior has crossed from normal debate into disrespect or risk.

### Core caution

Use national culture as a starting hypothesis, never as a diagnosis. Japanese, Chinese, and American employees vary by company, region, generation, gender, role, personality, industry, and international experience.

The best learner outcome is not 'act American.' It is 'read the room accurately, lead clearly, and protect both results and dignity.'

## Course objectives

- Recognize when American directness is a challenge to an idea rather than a rejection of the person.
- Respond to fast, blunt, public disagreement without freezing, over-apologizing, or escalating unnecessarily.
- Lead meetings with clear decision rights, visible confidence, and enough openness for American staff to trust the process.
- Use pushback that is firm, evidence-based, and relationship-safe.
- Handle performance issues, deadlines, ownership gaps, and cross-border tension in a US branch setting.
- Repair conflict after a difficult exchange and distinguish normal debate from unacceptable disrespect.

## The American Idea-Combat Personality

Many US branches include at least one high-energy professional who treats ideas as objects to be stress-tested in public. This person may interrupt, speak quickly, use blunt negatives, challenge senior people, and sound as if they are verbally assaulting an opinion. Their intent may be completely non-hostile. In their mind, they are doing the work: finding the weak point before the customer, market, auditor, or competitor finds it.

A useful label is the adversarial collaborator. This person attacks the proposal so the team can make it stronger. They may say, 'That will never work,' then happily eat lunch with the person who proposed it. They often separate person and idea more sharply than managers from more face-sensitive or harmony-oriented environments expect.

## Common signals

- Blunt challenge: 'No,' 'I disagree,' 'That is not realistic,' or 'The assumption is wrong.'
- Fast turn-taking: they may enter before a pause feels complete to a Japanese or Chinese listener.
- Public testing: they challenge in the meeting because the meeting is where the work is happening.
- Low ritual repair: they may not apologize because they do not think damage occurred.
- Quick emotional reset: five minutes after debate, they may act relaxed and friendly.

## What it may mean

- I am engaged enough to test this seriously.
- I respect you enough to be direct.
- I believe the best idea should survive challenge.
- I expect you, as the leader, to answer objections with evidence and then decide.

- I am not attacking your status unless I move from the work to your character, intelligence, accent, nationality, or dignity.

## What it does not excuse

Non-hostile intent does not erase impact. Managers should not allow personal insults, ridicule, discriminatory comments, harassment, threats, repeated domination, or retaliation. A healthy American debate style is direct about work and respectful toward people. The manager's job is to protect both.

| Type                       | Example                                                                  | Manager response                                             |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Normal debate           | No, I disagree. The timeline is unrealistic.                             | Answer with evidence; invite alternatives.                   |
| 2. Strong but task-focused | That assumption is wrong, and here is why.                               | Slow the pace; restate the business issue.                   |
| 3. Process problem         | Repeated interruption, sarcasm, eye-rolling, or dominating.              | Intervene: set meeting rules and protect the floor.          |
| 4. Personal attack         | You clearly do not understand this business.                             | Stop and redirect: behavior is not acceptable.               |
| 5. Escalation issue        | Threats, slurs, harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or safety risk. | Pause the exchange and involve HR or appropriate leadership. |

## Culture Maps for US Branch Managers

The following patterns explain why a meeting can feel rude to one manager and normal to another participant. They are not moral rankings. They are operating systems. A leader becomes effective by seeing which operating system is active and making expectations explicit.

### Patterns that often surprise Japanese managers

- Consensus before meeting vs debate inside meeting: US employees may expect the meeting itself to change the idea, not merely confirm prior alignment.
- Respect through challenge: a younger specialist may disagree publicly because they believe expertise matters more than seniority in that moment.
- Quality and preparation vs speed and iteration: US teams may accept a provisional answer if it lets work move now.
- Silence as ambiguity: quiet listening may be read as agreement, lack of confidence, or lack of opinion.
- Apology patterns: repeated apology can reduce authority if the issue requires ownership and corrective action instead.

### Patterns that often surprise Chinese managers

- Face and public disagreement: US employees may challenge in public without intending to reduce a leader's face.
- Hierarchy vs delegated ownership: employees may expect a manager to define the goal, then let local owners shape execution.
- Relationship trust vs process trust: US staff may trust clear rules, documented decisions, and fair process even when personal relationship is limited.
- Indirect refusal: softened no can be mistaken for maybe, creating later frustration.
- Central approval: employees may lose confidence if every meaningful answer appears to require distant permission.

### Other differences foreign managers may encounter

| Difference           | Possible US interpretation                                                                                           | Manager move                                                               |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Visible disagreement | Many US employees see disagreement as contribution. A quiet meeting may look unproductive or politically controlled. | Invite objections early, set time limits, and close with a clear decision. |

| Difference                      | Possible US interpretation                                                                                                       | Manager move                                                                         |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Speed and provisional decisions | Teams may prefer a decision that can be revised over a perfect decision that arrives late.                                       | Use pilot language: 'We will test this for two weeks and review the data.'           |
| Self-promotion                  | Employees may describe their own achievements directly. This can sound boastful to managers from more modesty-oriented contexts. | Ask for evidence and impact; do not punish appropriate visibility.                   |
| Hierarchy                       | US staff may challenge a boss in public and still accept the boss's authority after the decision.                                | Do not read challenge automatically as rebellion. Name the decision point.           |
| Written accountability          | Emails, meeting notes, goals, and performance records carry heavy weight.                                                        | Document expectations, decisions, and follow-up in neutral language.                 |
| HR and legal sensitivity        | Rules around harassment, discrimination, retaliation, wage/time, disability, and protected leave are serious.                    | Partner with HR early. This curriculum is not legal advice.                          |
| Work-life boundaries            | Some American employees protect evenings, weekends, vacation, and family obligations strongly.                                   | Clarify urgency standards and avoid implying loyalty requires constant availability. |
| Psychological safety            | Employees may expect the right to raise risks without punishment.                                                                | Thank people for surfacing risk, then evaluate the risk rigorously.                  |
| Friendliness vs friendship      | Warm small talk may not mean deep personal relationship; direct debate may not mean personal dislike.                            | Track behavior over time rather than one emotional signal.                           |
| Indirect no                     | Phrases like 'we will consider it' may be read as genuine possibility in the US.                                                 | When the answer is no, say no with a reason, an alternative, or a next condition.    |

## Curriculum Map

The full course is eight 90-minute modules plus optional coaching. It can also be taught as a two-day intensive or as eight short workshops over a quarter. Each module includes cultural interpretation, leadership behavior, controlled language practice, role-play, and transfer to the learner's actual workplace.

### Full course sequence

| Module                                         | Core question                                                                                                                                                                                              | Main performance outcome                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Reading the US Branch Room                  | American workplaces often reward visible participation, concise opinions, and quick objection. Silence may be misread as weak agreement, lack of expertise, or disengagement.                              | Personal observation checklist for the learner's own branch.; A one-sentence self-grounding response for surprise pushback. |
| 2. The American Idea-Combat Style              | Some Americans verbally attack an opinion with intensity while feeling no personal hostility. They may believe they are improving the plan, respecting the seriousness of the work, or proving engagement. | Idea-combat decoder card.; Boundary phrase bank.                                                                            |
| 3. Confident Leadership Without Overcorrecting | Managers who are used to indirect authority may overcorrect in the US by becoming either too soft and invisible or too hard and controlling. The target is calm clarity plus credible openness.            | Decision close template.; Personal leadership sentence patterns.                                                            |
| 4. The Pushback Ladder                         | Effective US branch pushback usually moves from curiosity to evidence to consequence to decision. Jumping straight to authority can look defensive; staying only curious can look weak.                    | Pushback ladder worksheet.; Three polished pushback scripts for the learner's real branch context.                          |

| Module                                                                         | Core question                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Main performance outcome                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5. Meetings, Interruptions, and Decision Rights                                | US meetings often mix discussion, debate, decision, and performance display. Managers need to name the meeting mode and control the process without suppressing useful challenge.                                         | Meeting opening script.; Decision record template.                                            |
| 6. Feedback, Accountability, and Face                                          | American employees may expect direct feedback, but they also expect fairness, specificity, documentation, and respect. Public embarrassment, vague criticism, or surprise consequences can create serious trust problems. | Feedback conversation planner.; Accountability email template.                                |
| 7. Cross-Border Tension: Headquarters, Local Staff, and the Manager in Between | Foreign managers in US branches often translate between headquarters expectations and local American expectations. The manager must protect strategic intent while making local reality speak clearly.                    | Headquarters update format.; Local autonomy explanation script.                               |
| 8. Repair, Escalation, and Long-Term Trust                                     | A tense exchange does not have to damage the relationship if the manager can repair quickly, clarify intent, set norms, and follow through. Some behavior, however, must be escalated.                                    | Personal repair script.; Team debate norm charter.; Capstone rubric score and coaching notes. |

## Fast-track version

1. Hour 1: orientation, culture maps, and the idea-combat decoder.
2. Hour 2: pushback ladder and confidence markers.
3. Hour 3: meeting control, interruption management, and decision close.
4. Hour 4: feedback and accountability conversations.
5. Hour 5: headquarters/local translation role-plays.
6. Hour 6: capstone simulation, peer feedback, and personal action plan.

## Instructor Module Plans

### Module 1. Reading the US Branch Room (90 minutes)

American workplaces often reward visible participation, concise opinions, and quick objection. Silence may be misread as weak agreement, lack of expertise, or disengagement.

#### Learning objectives

- Separate personal identity from workplace role behavior.
- Name three US branch signals that can feel aggressive but may be intended as participation.
- Identify personal triggers that make pushback harder to answer.

#### Core concepts

- Low-context communication: the speaker is expected to put more meaning into words, not leave it in shared background.
- Equality theater: even with hierarchy, employees may speak as if ideas compete on the same table.
- Task trust: some Americans build trust by testing plans and finding defects early.

#### Activities

1. Perception split: learners label ten workplace comments as hostile, neutral, or unclear; then compare possible US interpretations.
2. Room scan: learners map where authority, expertise, emotion, and decision rights appear in a meeting.

3. Trigger journal: learners write what behaviors make them feel disrespected, then convert each one into a question to test intent.

### Learner outputs

- Personal observation checklist for the learner's own branch.
- A one-sentence self-grounding response for surprise pushback.

### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 2. The American Idea-Combat Style (90 minutes)

Some Americans verbally attack an opinion with intensity while feeling no personal hostility. They may believe they are improving the plan, respecting the seriousness of the work, or proving engagement.

### Learning objectives

- Describe the difference between idea attack, relationship attack, and status attack.
- Practice staying present when language sounds stronger than the speaker's intent.
- Set boundaries when the attack becomes personal or disrespectful.

### Core concepts

- Adversarial collaboration: two people pressure-test the same problem from different sides.
- Blunt cognitive shorthand: comments like 'That won't work' may mean 'I see a risk we need to solve,' not 'You are incompetent.'
- After-conflict reset: many Americans expect the relationship to continue normally after a heated exchange if the conflict stayed task-focused.

### Activities

1. Decode the line: learners rewrite harsh-sounding comments into likely business concerns.
2. Heat meter: learners place comments on a scale from normal debate to manager intervention required.
3. Boundary drill: learners practice 'Challenge the plan, not the person' and 'Let's keep this about the data.'

### Learner outputs

- Idea-combat decoder card.
- Boundary phrase bank.

### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 3. Confident Leadership Without Overcorrecting (90 minutes)

Managers who are used to indirect authority may overcorrect in the US by becoming either too soft and invisible or too hard and controlling. The target is calm clarity plus credible openness.

### Learning objectives

- Use leader language that shows ownership without shutting down input.
- Make a decision after disagreement and preserve commitment.

- Explain the reason behind a decision without sounding defensive.

### Core concepts

- Authority as service to clarity: the manager reduces ambiguity about goal, constraints, process, and decision.
- Confidence markers: clear verbs, direct ownership, time boundaries, and explicit next steps.
- Openness markers: invitation to risks, evidence requests, and visible revision when the facts change.

### Activities

1. Weak/strong/overstrong sorting: learners compare manager statements and identify the leadership signal.
2. Decision close practice: learners decide after three objections and state what will happen next.
3. Two-minute rationale: learners explain a decision using goal, evidence, tradeoff, and commitment.

### Learner outputs

- Decision close template.
- Personal leadership sentence patterns.

#### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 4. The Pushback Ladder (90 minutes)

Effective US branch pushback usually moves from curiosity to evidence to consequence to decision. Jumping straight to authority can look defensive; staying only curious can look weak.

### Learning objectives

- Use four levels of pushback based on the risk and the relationship.
- Push back upward, sideways, and downward.
- Avoid common traps: apology loops, vague disagreement, status arguments, and hidden no.

### Core concepts

- Level 1: clarify the assumption.
- Level 2: add data or operational detail.
- Level 3: name the business consequence.
- Level 4: make or request a decision.

### Activities

1. Ladder building: learners turn one disagreement into four stronger versions.
2. Peer challenge: one learner pushes; the other asks what evidence would change the decision.
3. Upward pushback: learners practice disagreeing with headquarters or a senior US executive.

### Learner outputs

- Pushback ladder worksheet.
- Three polished pushback scripts for the learner's real branch context.

#### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 5. Meetings, Interruptions, and Decision Rights (90 minutes)

US meetings often mix discussion, debate, decision, and performance display. Managers need to name the meeting mode and control the process without suppressing useful challenge.

### Learning objectives

- Distinguish brainstorm, debate, alignment, decision, and execution meetings.
- Interrupt constructively and reclaim the floor.
- Convert noisy discussion into action owners, deadlines, and decision records.

### Core concepts

- Interruption may signal energy or urgency; repeated interruption can still require process control.
- Decision rights must be visible: recommend, consult, decide, veto, execute.
- Meeting closure is a leadership act, not an administrative detail.

### Activities

1. Meeting mode cards: learners announce the mode and rules for five meeting types.
2. Floor control drill: learners interrupt politely but firmly in three levels of intensity.
3. Decision record: learners convert a messy transcript into decisions, risks, owners, and next steps.

### Learner outputs

- Meeting opening script.
- Decision record template.

#### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 6. Feedback, Accountability, and Face (90 minutes)

American employees may expect direct feedback, but they also expect fairness, specificity, documentation, and respect. Public embarrassment, vague criticism, or surprise consequences can create serious trust problems.

### Learning objectives

- Give direct feedback without humiliation.
- Name performance gaps in observable terms.
- Understand why documentation and HR partnership matter in US branches.

### Core concepts

- Behavior, impact, expectation, support, consequence.
- Private dignity: direct does not mean public shaming.
- Process fairness: US employees often evaluate discipline by whether expectations were explicit and consistently applied.

### Activities

1. Feedback rewrite: learners convert vague criticism into behavior-based feedback.
2. Face-safe directness: learners practice direct messages that preserve dignity.
3. Escalation map: learners identify when to involve HR, legal, or senior leadership.

### Learner outputs

- Feedback conversation planner.
- Accountability email template.

### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 7. Cross-Border Tension: Headquarters, Local Staff, and the Manager in Between (90 minutes)

Foreign managers in US branches often translate between headquarters expectations and local American expectations. The manager must protect strategic intent while making local reality speak clearly.

### Learning objectives

- Explain headquarters constraints without blaming headquarters.
- Represent US branch realities upward with evidence and options.
- Prevent employees from feeling that decisions are mysterious, delayed, or already made elsewhere.

### Core concepts

- Two-way translation: headquarters needs local evidence; local staff need business context.
- Local autonomy expectations: many US employees expect influence over execution details.
- Credibility under constraint: a manager can be honest about limits and still lead with authority.

### Activities

1. Constraint translation: learners turn 'Japan/China said no' into a business explanation.
2. Options memo: learners prepare three options for headquarters with tradeoffs and a recommendation.
3. Employee trust role-play: learners answer 'Do we actually have any say in this?'

### Learner outputs

- Headquarters update format.
- Local autonomy explanation script.

### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Module 8. Repair, Escalation, and Long-Term Trust (90 minutes)

A tense exchange does not have to damage the relationship if the manager can repair quickly, clarify intent, set norms, and follow through. Some behavior, however, must be escalated.

### Learning objectives

- Use a repair conversation after a difficult meeting.
- Separate normal disagreement from bullying, harassment, discrimination, or retaliation risk.
- Build a team norm that allows challenge without personal attack.

### Core concepts

- Repair sequence: name, own, clarify, reset, invite.
- Norm setting: teams debate better when the manager defines what good challenge looks like.

- Escalation is not failure; it is part of protecting people and the business.

### Activities

1. Repair script rehearsal: learners practice after three types of conflict.
2. Norm charter: teams draft debate rules for a US branch meeting.
3. Capstone simulation: learners lead a 20-minute meeting with objections, interruptions, and a final decision.

### Learner outputs

- Personal repair script.
- Team debate norm charter.
- Capstone rubric score and coaching notes.

### Facilitator note

Keep the discussion concrete. Ask learners to describe actual words, timing, channel, role, and business stakes. Avoid debates about which national culture is better. The question is: what will this behavior mean in this branch, and what leadership move will work here?

## Assessment and Coaching

### Pre-course diagnostic

- Learner describes a recent US branch conflict and identifies what was said, what they felt, what they did, and what happened next.
- Learner rates confidence from 1 to 5 in meetings, pushback, feedback, interruption control, and repair.
- Instructor conducts a five-minute role-play with blunt disagreement and notes default response patterns.

### Performance rubric

| Skill            | Developing                                    | Proficient                                    | Strong                                                         |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Decode intent    | Treats most bluntness as personal disrespect. | Separates tone, content, and possible intent. | Tests intent quickly and stays focused on business stakes.     |
| Push back        | Uses vague disagreement or retreats.          | Uses evidence and consequences clearly.       | Adapts intensity to risk, role, and relationship.              |
| Lead meetings    | Lets debate sprawl or shuts it down early.    | Names mode, controls floor, closes decisions. | Creates useful dissent and strong commitment after decision.   |
| Boundary setting | Ignores disrespect or overreacts.             | Redirects personal comments to work issues.   | Sets norms early and escalates serious behavior appropriately. |
| Repair           | Avoids follow-up after tension.               | Clarifies intent and resets expectations.     | Turns conflict into a team norm and stronger trust.            |

### Capstone simulation

Learners lead a meeting about a delayed product launch. The instructor assigns roles: sales wants speed, engineering wants quality, headquarters wants global consistency, finance wants cost control, and HR watches team behavior. The manager must surface objections, use the pushback ladder, protect the floor, make a decision or define the next decision gate, and repair any tense moment.

### Suggested further reading

- Edward T. Hall, *Beyond Culture*.
- Geert Hofstede, Gert Jan Hofstede, and Michael Minkov, *Cultures and Organizations*.

- Erin Meyer, The Culture Map.
- Stella Ting-Toomey and John Oetzel, Managing Intercultural Conflict Effectively.
- Robert House and colleagues, Culture, Leadership, and Organizations: The GLOBE Study.
- Amy Edmondson, The Fearless Organization.